



**FORTUNA ADMISSIONS**  
**INSIDER'S TOP TIPS**  
**FOR APPLYING TO**  
**UCLA Anderson**



## FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR UCLA ANDERSON

### ABOUT THE SCHOOL

UCLA Anderson defines its community by three core qualities: share success, think fearlessly and drive change. It's lauded for pioneering the nation's first field-study program nearly 50 years ago—the Applied Management Research Program—and establishing the Easton Technology Management Center. Anderson's motto, "Think in the Next," speaks to a penchant for bold thinkers who are unafraid to chart new pathways and effect change.

The incoming class of 360 MBA candidates is nested within a powerhouse university of more than 40,000 students, located in one of the most diverse cities in the U.S. As the world's 15th largest economy, LA is home to more than 300,000 small businesses, and its vibrant tech scene produces four times the GDP of Silicon Valley. Its reputation as a creative city in media and entertainment are unparalleled, but LA's strengths extend to sectors such as consulting, finance, health care and consumer products. This nexus of industry, creativity and business-creation offers noteworthy access to company visits, guest speakers, mentors and internships.

Anderson has a nine-course core curriculum includes the option to add a specialization for a deeper dive into a target industry or function. The second year of study is entirely by individual design, allowing students to choose from an array of electives. Students also complete an Applied Management Research project (AMR), a two-quarter capstone experience that synthesizes classroom learning and applies it in a real-world business setting.

### STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Entrepreneurship, finance, tech, communications and entertainment

### INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 2817

MBA Class Size: 360

Admissions Selectivity: 26%

Yield: 49.15%

Total Tuition: \$130,228

### POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Technology 29.5%; Consulting 20.4%; Finance 14.9%; Consumer Products 7.6%

Top Recruiters: Adobe, Amazon, American Airlines, Deloitte, Merrill Lynch, Microsoft, Netflix

Avg. Base Salary: \$121,843

Employment in 3 months: 90%

### MBA RANKINGS

|                 | 2012 | 2013 | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017 | 2018 | 2019 |
|-----------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|
| BusinessWeek    |      | 18   | -    | 11   | 13   | 22   | 19   | 17   |
| Financial Times |      | 15   | 13   | 14   | 14   | 17   | 15   | 14   |
| Forbes          | -    | 13   | -    | 17   | -    | 15   | -    | 16   |
| The Economist   |      | 15   | 12   | 11   | 7    | 10   | 6    | 7    |
| US News         | 15   | 14   | 16   | 15   | 15   | 15   | 16   | 16   |

### ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs

Avg. GMAT: 719

Avg. GPA: 3.5

Int'l Students: 33%

Female Students: 34%

### Deadlines for 2019-2020

Round 1: October 2, 2019

Round 2: January 8, 2020

Round 3: April 16, 2020 \*covid-19 update (3/30/20): applications accepted until June 1, 2020

Sources: UCLA Anderson, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, Forbes, The Economist, US News



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## ESSAYS 2019-2020

### Insider Essay Analysis for UCLA Anderson

#### By Jessica Chung

*Jessica joined Fortuna after a decade of experience with UCLA Anderson. Serving as Associate Director of Admissions, she evaluated and interviewed thousands of applications for the full-time MBA program. She also managed the program's global recruiting and admit events, advised on fellowship decisions for admitted students and collaborated on strategic projects.*

The revamped UCLA MBA essay questions for the 2019-2020 application season, and in keeping with broader MBA trends, significantly slimmed down word counts across the board. Gone is last year's question, "what are you passionate about and why," in favor of a prompt more reflective of Anderson's values and culture. And given the scant real estate for responding, the trick is conveying your story in a way that's concise, distinctive and memorable.

Following is some perspective on what Anderson is looking for, along with tips on how to tackle each essay to maximize your chances of admissions success.

For context, first-time applicants must respond to two short answer questions (your MBA goals/why Anderson) and one essay question. Let's decode each of them:

#### a) Tell us about your MBA goals AND why you are applying to UCLA Anderson now:

- Describe your short term and long term goals (150 words maximum)
- Why is UCLA Anderson a good school for you? (150 words maximum)

While the spirit of this question hasn't changed, previous applicants were given 500 words to respond, and it's clear Anderson wants you to be as incisive as possible. In the first part of this question, the school is looking for assurance that you've meaningfully thought through why you're applying at this point in your life and what specific career enhancements you're hoping to gain. In a few well-chosen words, you need to convey career goals that are logical, ambitious yet achievable. You must be able to convincingly connect the dots from where you've been and where you're going, and why the Anderson MBA is the essential next step.

First, understand the distinction between short and long term goals and how they should work together in your career vision (my Fortuna colleague, Heidi Hillis, outlines the key elements of each in her [recent article on the topic](#), along with specific examples). Whereas your long-term vision is usually around 10 years out, signaling the impact you hope to make, your short-term goals are the stepping stones on your way to that end goal, and they need to be specific. (Caution: If there's a perceived disconnect between your career direction and your future plans, that will raise a flag.)

Also, consider how other elements of your application, such as the MBA resume, can be tuned to reinforce key elements of your career vision, transferrable skills, inherent leadership capacities, and managerial skills. Given the brevity allotted in the short answer question, you'll want to make sure that your resume highlights key career accomplishments and impact, along with extracurricular activities that reinforce the narrative you're presenting.



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### Insider Essay Analysis for UCLA Anderson, *continued*.

Note that part two of this question is connected to your career goals versus broken out in a separate question. As such, you should respond to 'why Anderson' in the professional development context versus veering too extensively to cultural fit (although it's okay to weave this in as appropriate). That's because Anderson also wants to make sure it's well-positioned to support your job search and placement. To this end, look at the professional organizations, clubs, and convenings that take place on campus – like those related to entrepreneurship, entertainment, retail or sports management, to name just a few. If you're looking to expand your global focus, mention the opportunities on offer through Anderson's global tracks or internationally focused AMR (Applied Management Research). And when you do, don't just list what's of interest but truly connect the dots with your aspirations and career plans.

Again, research here is fundamental, and Anderson puts a premium on relationship building. They want to see evidence that you've gone above and beyond the information available online to reach out to students, alumni and other members of the community. Look for ways to weave in insights from one of these conversations.

Onward to the new required essay:

**b) At Anderson, we believe our students are engaged, courageous, humble, and open. Describe a time when you demonstrated one of these traits in your personal life. (250 words max.)**

This year, Anderson is framing its query in the context of the culture it's actively seeking to cultivate. This is also a specific invitation to depart from your professional achievements and get personal, to showcase your personality and the values that drive you. Anderson deeply values students who are active participants and collaborators, who are motivated to succeed but not at the expense of holding others back. It's a student-driven community where the notion of 'ambitious yet humble' is highly prized.

Consider the quality that resonates most deeply for you. In getting started, give yourself some latitude to brainstorm pivotal events that shape you, and allow yourself to stretch back to childhood to see what percolates up. Use story to describe one of the qualities (don't be tempted to do more in such limited space) and portray what you learned from this experience – don't waste valuable words just chronicling what happened.

As you reflect on initial drafts, consider: What meaning can be discerned from your story and what does it say about you? How will the story you tell convey the kind of leader you are and hope to become? Have a trusted friend or colleague read your essay. If they can't see you in the story or feel an emotional resonance, then try again until it comes through. As one student quips in Anderson's jazzy two-minute ['how to get in' video](#), a great story creates a great application.

**A final reflection:** don't let the need for brevity rob your responses of feeling. One of the biggest mistakes I've seen is showing a lack of enthusiasm. If your tone doesn't convey excitement or energy, it won't stand out. Same if you've only done the bare bones research and your essays lack nuanced and meaningful insight on the program or yourself. Dare to have a little fun and show Anderson the love.



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By Jessica Chung

## Tip #1 – Get to know the community

Adcoms expect candidates to go beyond surface level research when getting to know Anderson and the community. While you can meet school reps at events throughout the year, making an effort to forge deeper connections with students and alumni – especially those with similar backgrounds/goals – using their stories to support your candidacy is especially compelling. Students lead a ton of coffee chats during the summer in various cities, and during the school year also partake in webinars, info sessions, and host class visits. If you can't attend an in-person event, emailing officers of student clubs is another great way to learn more about careers/recruiting. Take advantage of these pathways to build relationships with students and learn their stories. If you reside in southern California, visiting campus is highly recommended.

## Tip #2 – Know Anderson's principles

A few years back, the school [defined its driving principles](#) – Share Success, Think Fearlessly, Drive Change – which adcoms use as a filter for assessing each candidate. The website has some good examples with specific student, alumni and faculty stories illuminating these principles in action. This year's essay question #2 challenges you to reflect deeply on a specific incident/example of a time you demonstrated traits that align with these values, which also goes to show how much more important culture and fit are in the evaluation process than ever before. Given only 250 words are allowed for the essay, I recommend focusing on one trait/example and discussing it in depth.

## Tip #3 – Understand the culture

Piggybacking on the previous point, strong cultural fit is an extremely important aspect of the evaluation process. Anderson prides itself on being very supportive and looks for individuals who are driven but not cutthroat competitive. Through the application and interview, the admissions team scours the pool for individuals with these qualities – being highly collaborative but with a sense of humbleness and openness to feedback. There's a strong entrepreneurial spirit in the program as well, so showing this mindset (not necessarily being an entrepreneur, but demonstrating innovative thinking within your company) is crucial.

## Tip #4 – Involvement is crucial

Anderson has a rich tradition of active involvement outside the classroom, and the school highly encourages creating new clubs or events as needs of the student community evolves. Most activities on campus are student driven or led, and it's a big priority to craft a class that will uphold this legacy each year. History of involvement in extracurriculars, volunteer work, etc., is important beyond a superficial level, so you should demonstrate true passion and dedication to the causes and communities to which you belong. If you don't have a robust extracurricular profile and want to beef it up in the time before submitting applications, I suggest looking for roles that go beyond being a mere "member" and make a substantive contribution – organize an event, revamp an organization's social media strategy, analyze ROI on events and suggest improvements, etc.



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### Tip #5 – Emphasize location

Candidates should be familiar with LA/SoCal/CA's vibrant business culture, diversity, and pioneering spirit, and connect it back to their goals and/or “why Anderson.” What really frustrates adcoms are applicants who apply with a very stereotyped mindset about Anderson – e.g. it's only for anyone interested in entertainment, there aren't many opportunities in finance/consulting, it's a “regional” school and you can't get a job outside of CA, etc. Understanding the benefits of the school's strategic LA location, and not falling (even unconsciously) into stereotypes or biases (such as “LA is more laid back than east coast cities”) will signal that you're a serious candidate. Be familiar with LA's strengths – e.g., virtually every major company is headquartered or has an office in Southern CA, LA is the world's 16<sup>th</sup> largest economy, and Silicon Beach is a major tech hub bringing in billions in VC funding each year.

### Tip #6 – Resume and Letters of Recommendation

This year's essay questions have been truncated, with a max of 300 words for part A and 250 words for part B. Thus, there's minimal space to expound on past professional accomplishments within your narrative, so it's critical to ensure your resume shows clear career evolution, leadership, and impact in each of your roles. Make each bullet count! It's also important to be very intentional when selecting the two individuals who will write the letters of recommendation, as the admissions team will look to the recommendations for further evidence of your professional strengths and the outcomes you've driven. Recommendations that are enthusiastic but lack substance (no specific examples to support your best qualities) won't really move the needle. Though a current supervisor is preferred, it is not required (but at least one should come from a professional source), so it's okay to think outside the box a bit.

### Tip #6 – Articulate focused and attainable career goals

Since essays are quite limited in space, it will be a challenge to present your case with enthusiasm and authenticity. For essay A, try to be somewhat specific in your short-term plan without being too narrow. Giving an example of a company and function as a possible post-MBA career can be a good way to do this. Longer term goals (7-10 years out) can be broader but should still logically connect to your immediate post-MBA plans. Remember the admissions team will consider the transferable skills and experiences you will bring, as well as your motivations and the research you've done to learn about your next career move (especially if you are planning to change industry, function, or both), to assess viability.



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### More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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